

SIX-BANDED ARMADILLO

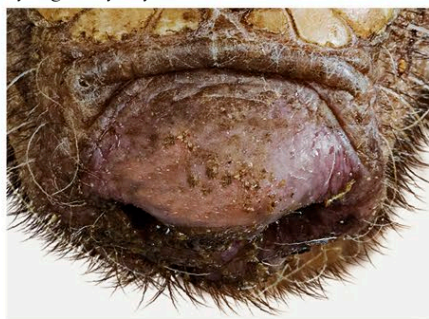
Euphractus sexcinctus

Despite its name, this species of armadillo may have anything from six to eight armoured bands around its middle. The upper part of the animal's body is covered by a sturdy carapace. The carapace is made up of plates of bone, topped with a thin covering of horny material, and it is embedded in the armadillo's skin. The bands act as joints in the carapace, giving the animal flexibility, although it is unable to curl completely into a ball like some other species. The six-banded armadillo is diurnal, spending the daylight hours trundling about its home range in search of food. It has a varied diet, ranging from roots and shoots to invertebrates and carrion.



< SHIELDED EYE

The armadillo's eyes are protected by the headshield at the expense of a slightly restricted field of vision. As it has poor eyesight anyway, this makes little difference.



< NOSE

Armadillos have an acute sense of smell. They sniff and snuffle their way to most meals, and can easily detect food buried in the soil.

head is narrow and pointed and protected by a shield made of fused bony plates

< STRONG LEGS

The armadillo has short but powerful legs. When digging, soil loosened by the front feet is kicked out of the hole by the hind feet.

^ HAIRY SKIN

The bony carapace is interrupted by six to eight bands, which are separated by flexible skin. Long, bristly hairs sprout from between the bands – this is one of the hairy armadillos.

TAIL >

Glands at the base of the armadillo's tail release scent through small holes in the armour plates. The scent marks the armadillo's territory.



^ CLAWS

Long, strong claws allow the armadillo to dig rapidly into hard ground. In a matter of minutes it is able to excavate a trench deep enough to bury itself in.



SIZE 40–50 cm (16–20 in)

HABITAT Forest and savanna

DISTRIBUTION S. America, mainly south of Amazon Basin

DIET Omnivorous

